

magazine



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HUNGER HAS LEFT THE CHAT

The GLP-1 drug – now available as generics in India – cuts out ‘food noise’. Can it solve the world diabetes capital’s obesity crisis, which goes beyond body size?



digestive disorders usually resolve themselves, and those like pancreatitis, thyroid cancer and blindness are very uncommon. But GLP-1s are still not the solution for diabetes and obesity crises in our country.”

Appetite has a new name: food noise

How exactly does a Glucagon-like-Peptides-1 (GLP-1) receptor agonist work? Approved for weight loss besides type-2 diabetes in 2021 in the U.S., GLP-1 is a natural metabolic hormone produced in the gut that regulates blood sugar by stimulating insulin release, reducing glucagon secretion and increasing feelings of satiety or a feeling of fullness. The GLP-1 receptor agonists mimic this hormone for managing type-2 diabetes and obesity.

Appetite has a new name in the Ozempic-boosted world: food noise. And the hyped magic of these drugs rests on this one property – cutting out food noise, or mental chatter about hunger/eating, in an obese or/and diabetic person completely. Food noise in India can be punishment. You may hear it, but you can't give in to it simply because you have no access to proper nutrition or enough food. We have parallel epidemics of malnutrition/undernourishment and obesity – around 172 million Indians are undernourished, according to the 2025 State of Food Security and Nutrition in the World (SOFI), and the National Family Health Survey-5 (NFHS-5, 2019-21) data shows that approximately 24% women and 23% men in India are either overweight or obese.

We are in the thick of this GLP-1 revolution, and doctors in India, the diabetes capital of the world – where an obesity epidemic is swelling across its 1.47 billion population – are cautiously optimistic. Dr. David Chandy, director, endocrinology and diabetology, Sir H.N. Reliance Foundation Hospital, Mumbai, explains the euphoria: “Newer agents in this family, and dual incretin drugs such as tirzepatide, have changed the conversation because, for the first time, we have medicines that can produce meaningful and, sometimes, dramatic weight reduction. American Diabetes Association guidelines now place weight management centrally in diabetes care, and GLP-1-based therapy is among the preferred approaches when weight loss is a major goal.”

India is just a year into GLP-1 prescriptions, and no structured data on usage is available yet, but pharmaceutical company representatives informally estimate the Indian market at around ₹100 crore. In March this year, the Dutch pharmaceutical giant Novo Nordic lost the patent for Semaglutide, the most used GLP-1 drug, for diabetes and weight loss. India leads in the number of generics that were announced in the wake of this patent expiry.

Several brands are incoming, which includes Sun Pharmaceutical's Sematrinity and Noveltreat (priced between ₹2,690 and ₹7,490, depending on dose). "We are working closely with government institutes and trying to make the generics available widely," says a Sun Pharmaceutical spokesperson. Last week, Novo Nordisk reportedly slashed prices of both Ozempic and Wegovy by 36% and 48%, respectively, in India – giving the generics more competition in the rapidly widening market.

CONTINUED ON
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Saniukta Sharma

Mukta Dhond has a new monthly ritual. “I have to take my 20 pairs of jeans to the tailor for size alterations,” says the 49-year-old Mumbai-based television producer.

A single mother who has been battling obesity for a large part of her life, she decided it was time for a transformation when during a Scotland vacation with her toddler son in 2024, she was left gasping after a steep climb. Dhond was a pre-diabetic then. “He would run up the hills and I would be far behind. I realised it was time to change things,” she recalls. From weighing 117 kg in March 2025, when she started her GLP-1 journey with Ozempic, Dhond is at 95 kg today. She points to a feeling of reinvention and liberation – a “game-changer”, in her words.

By 2029, there will be around 40 million global users of the GLP-1 drug, forecasts a UBS Investment Bank report. Dhond's journey is similar to that of millions around the world for whom obesity has cumulatively chipped at metabolic parameters such as insulin resistance, and body image-related self-esteem. Dhond is the ideal GLP-1 user, according to standards set by Dr. Alexandra Sowa, a New York-based internal medicine and obesity expert, in her book *The Ozempic Revolution* (2025), one of the first comprehensive, experience-based guides to a fulfilling GLP-1 journey: "You need to know how to thrive. How to eat, think, live and most importantly, how to change your relationship with food," she writes.

Dhond's fitness routine includes swimming, strength training thrice a week, a short walk after every meal, monthly blood work, and bi-monthly follow-ups with her endocrinologist. She spends up to ₹20,000 a month. GLP-1 drugs (injections) cost ₹8,000-₹10,000 depending on the dose. The generics, now available in pharmacies with a prescription, will cost ₹3,500-₹4,500. "They are expensive," says Dr. V. Mohan, Chennai-based diabetologist and Madras Diabetes Research Foundation chairman. "Even after the price reduction because of the introduction of generics, they are beyond the reach of the common man."

The magic pill, a new promise

After six months, when Dhond's doctor changed the prescription to Mounjaro, her weight loss journey accelerated. Her Body Mass Index when she started her GLP-1 journey was 45 (the normal range is up to 23). Chronic pains vanished and several blood parameters became normal, but her thyroid levels dropped to zero, and "the muscle loss and sagging were unreal". With sustained fitness and diet protocols – a non-vegetarian diet of lean proteins, high quality fats such as olive oil and avocado, and minimal carbohydrate – her thyroid levels and muscle health improved.

GLP-1s can lead to excessive muscle loss and amplify an already existing protein deficiency crisis in Indian diets across States and communities; doctors prescribing GLP-1s recommend a diet of small meals through the day, each meal containing specific portions of protein – vegetarian or non-vegetarian – according to personal needs.

The illustration depicts a woman with dark skin and curly hair, wearing a green short-sleeved shirt and red pants, standing centrally within a large, yellow, stylized outline of a human digestive tract. The digestive tract is represented by a thick, yellow, wavy line that forms a large loop around the woman's torso. Surrounding the woman and the digestive tract are several medical and health-related icons: a white bandage with a black cross is positioned on the upper left; a white pill with a black cross is on the upper right; a white pill bottle with a black cap and a label is on the lower right; and a white syringe with a black plunger is on the lower left. The background is a solid light blue color.

CETTIVIMAGES / ISTOCK

A journey similar to Dhond's is that of Bollywood filmmaker Hansal Mehta. Mehta weighed 105 kg three years ago. Different diets and exercise regimes failed. After being on Mounjaro for the past eight months, and supplementing it with strength training and cardio workouts four times a week, intermittent fasting on most days for 16-18 hours, and an array of supplements, Mehta is now at 73 kg. "My actual age is 57, but based on all health parameters, my metabolic age is 43," he says. His blood pressure levels, which remained high for two decades,

have stabilised. "At parties, my weight-loss journey often gets dismissed as 'Oh, he is on Mounjaro'. But the reality is I am doing so much more than just the pill," Mehta says.

Without lifestyle modification protocols, it can be a disappointing experience. A 33-year-old Bengaluru-based finance professional, speaking on condition of anonymity, says, "Both my wife and I were on Mounjaro, I was at 110 kg. Our doctor did not mention specific diet or exercise protocols. Our eating went down drastically and, in the process, we lost around

10 kg over four months. But I was always low on energy and mood, and had nausea all the time. Mounjaro definitely doesn't live up to its hype," he says. He adds his wife gained back 4 kg soon after they stopped the drug.

Among the few Indian diabetologists to use social media to explain realistically what these drugs can do, Dr. Mohan often fields questions from prospective users about its duration and side-effects. "One has to be prepared to take it for years, maybe even life-long, I tell them. Side-effects like nausea and



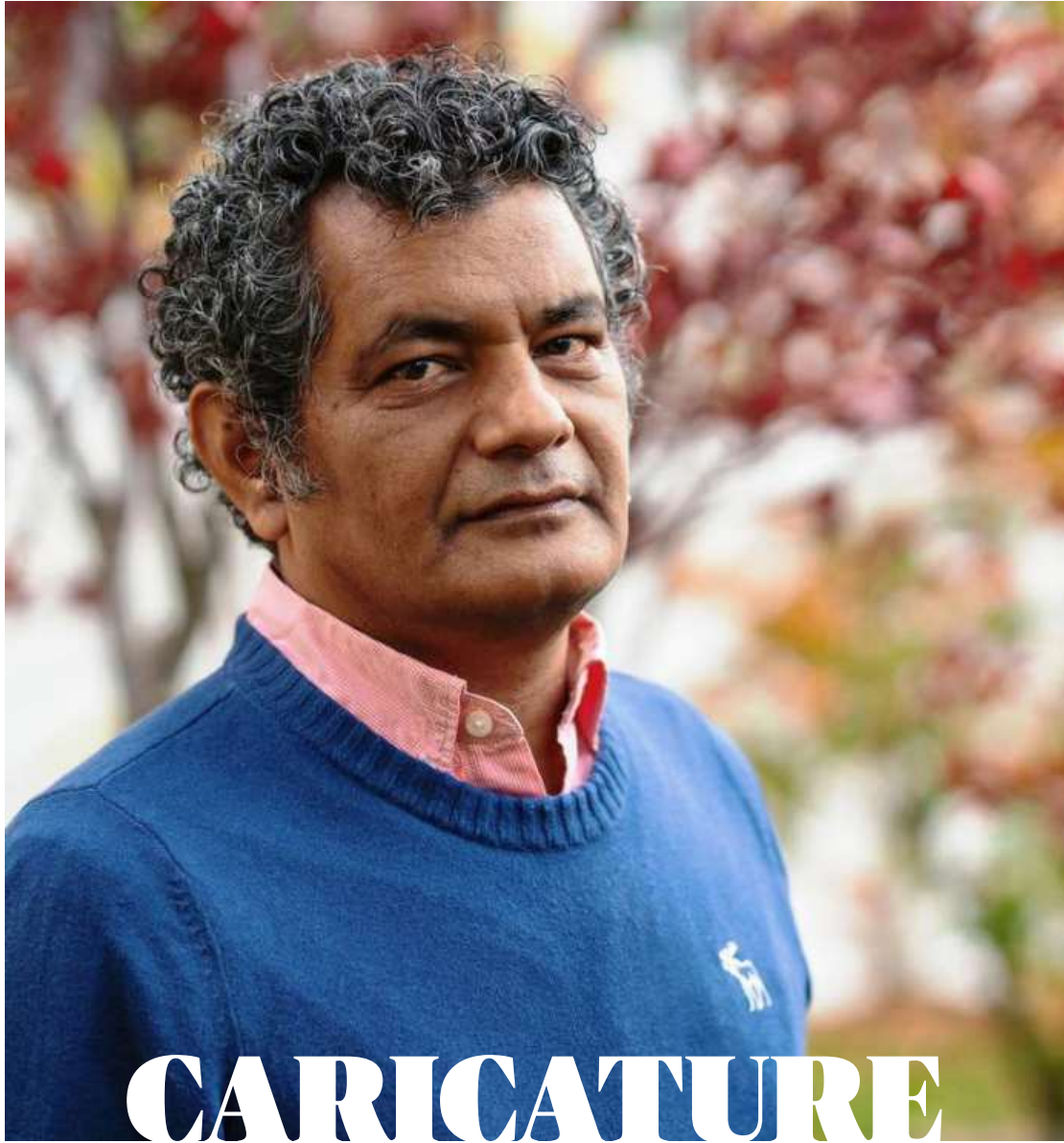
[The GLP-1 drugs] are expensive. Even after the price reduction because of the introduction of generics, they are beyond the reach of the common man. One has to be prepared to take it for years, maybe even life-long. Side-effects like nausea and digestive disorders usually resolve themselves, and those like pancreatitis, thyroid cancer and blindness are very uncommon. But GLP-1s are still not the solution for diabetes and obesity crises in our country

DR. V. MOHAN
Diabetologist, and Madras
Diabetes Research Foundation
chairman, Chennai



Added to 'sarcopenic obesity' [thin arms/legs, narrow chest, but bulging stomach; endemic in Indian populations] is a general lack of awareness – many people still equate absence of visible obesity with good health, which is not true in the Indian context

DR. RAVI SANKAR ERUKULAPATI
Senior consultant endocrinologist,
Apollo Hospitals, Jubilee Hills,
Hyderabad



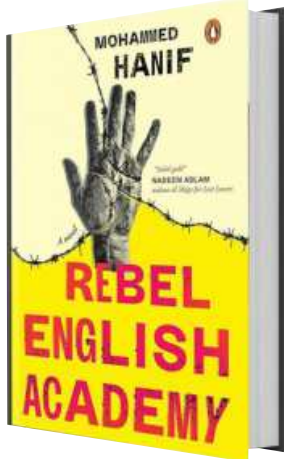
CARICATURE NATION

Pakistani author Mohammed Hanif's latest, about a malfunctioning republic, may fail to satisfy admirers of his tangy irreverence

Radhika Oberoi

Terrible events occur in Pakistan; its landscapes, volatile, its people, nervy. British-Pakistani journalist and author Mohammed Hanif's novels tell of these political uncertainties, and tragedies, with subversive mirth. His gaze is unrelenting in exposing the foibles of a republic that malfunctions, persistently, leaving a stupefied citizenry to deal with the aftermath of sudden violence. Cataclysm, in the guise of satire, is the quintessential Hanif narrative, and his latest novel, *Rebel English Academy*, adheres somewhat to his style. The opening chapter depicts the political events that underpin the novel. Zulfikar Ali Bhutto, former socialist Prime Minister, is hanged to death in a jail in Rawalpindi. Captain Gul, an intelligence officer who has fallen out of favour with his superiors, is transferred to nondescript OK Town. Hanif builds an atmosphere rife with simultaneous events that portend a complex and often hilarious narrative arc. Characters emerge from the dusty interiors, with sports

bags, pistols, and tormented pasts. **Idiosyncratic characters** In Ok Town, Sir Baghi, the founder of Rebel English Academy, a centre that teaches basic English to the locals, receives an unforeseen visitor. Young Sabiha Bano, recently widowed, has been brought to the academy by Molly or Maulvi Rafique of Gol Mosque. Baghi observes her with trepidation: "Ruin, he thinks, she is going to ruin us." The narrative smoulders with



Rebel English Academy
Mohammed Hanif
Hamish Hamilton
₹799

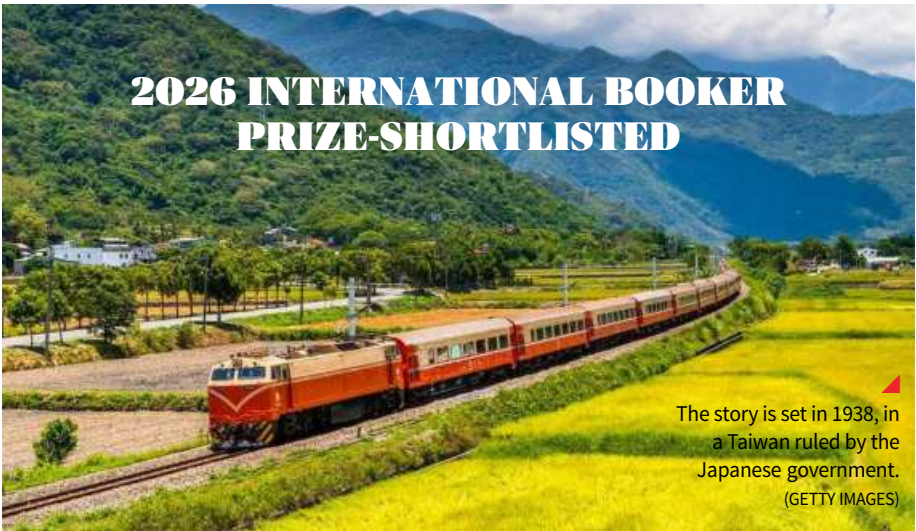
ruinous possibilities. Baghi's tuition centre-cum-residence is on the second floor of the mosque's complex, which is surrounded by bazaars. Grief-stricken *jywalas* are immolating themselves in these bazaars, to protest the execution of Bhutto. It is whispered that the proprietor of Iron Syrup & Other Herbs, Hakim Wasif Ali Wasif, has set himself on fire. Baghi gleans that the *hakim's* second wife, an athlete, has escaped the flames, and realises that she is none other than Sabiha, hiding out in his academy. Through a variety of plotted manoeuvres, Hanif depicts a town peopled with idiosyncratic characters: a pedlar of Himalayan aphrodisiacs, an advocate who is also a palmist, a photographer who plans to record a video of his own immolation, with the help of an apprentice. The landscape isn't always picturesque, and the provincial quietude is suggestive of recent unrest: "They drive past the boarded-up Satlaj Cotton Mills, a tattered red banner proclaiming 'Mill to the Workers' still fluttering on an adjacent electric pole." Captain Gul, whose voracious sexual appetite has earned him the moniker 'Lieutenant Piston',

Beauty is ephemeral in Mohammed Hanif's fictive world. (GETTY IMAGES)

is in OK Town for encounters both amorous and official. He embarks upon an investigation of local crime, including cracking down on rumour mongers and pamphleteers claiming that Bhutto is alive. He tracks down Shahid, proprietor of Shahid's Friendly Art Photo Studio, and asks the petrol-soaked man, on the verge of martyrdom, if he has any final wishes: "People usually ask for a last cigarette but given your current situation that would be highly irresponsible of me."

Fleeting respite *Rebel English Academy* attempts to portray a Pakistan strangled by Zia-ul-Haq's militaristic governance, with an extravagant tale that parodies the state and its martyrs. Hanif offers a burlesque, and it does manage to entertain. But it also falters, tripping over crudely jocular sentences and farcical episodes. The characters, with names that literally explain who they are (for instance, Baghi is Urdu for insurgent, and Shahid is Arabic for martyr), come off as caricatures, their personalities inflated as though they were colourful balloons at a fair. To add to the chaos of a third-person narrative exploding with characters and incidents are chapters in the first person. These are Sabiha's essays; she has been instructed by Baghi to write. "This is no place for guns," he tells her, insisting that she mine her own life for topics to write on: "Our Father, Our Mother, Our Cow if you have one. Feel free to make one up." And while the essays are revelatory, the shift in tone and style is barely perceptible. Hanif, the acutely-conscious satirist, refuses to relinquish authorial control. There are moments in the novel that offer fleeting respite from the action. A passage depicting Baghi's brief romance with his gay lover, Mehboob, is especially ripe with longing. The lovers take naps on railway tracks, steal kisses at street corners while a candle-lit May Day procession makes its purposeful way, read *Das Kapital* in front of mosques as worshippers emerge. But beauty is ephemeral in Hanif's fictive world, and in *Rebel English Academy*, even irony is brittle, crumbling into trite witticisms. The savage comedy of his terrific debut, *A Case of Exploding Mangoes* (2008), has dissipated in this novel. The unforgettable sketches of society's most vulnerable, in particular the junior nurse Alice Bhatti, in *Our Lady of Alice Bhatti* (2011), are missing from *Rebel English Academy*. Admirers of Hanif's tangy irreverence (like this reviewer) may be disappointed by the insipid aftertaste of his new work.

The reviewer is the author of two critically-acclaimed novels.



2026 INTERNATIONAL BOOKER PRIZE-SHORTLISTED

The story is set in 1938, in a Taiwan ruled by the Japanese government. (GETTY IMAGES)

Unequal affections

A fragile love story unfolds through food, language and quiet omissions

Nitika Francis
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A flower whose name I didn't know had bloomed in the cottage garden." Sentences like these, which argue that inexplicable feelings deserve to exist and be documented, are what make Yang Shuang-zi's *Taiwan Travelogue* a revelatory read. The novel, translated from the Mandarin original by Lin King, has garnered a spot on the 2026 International Booker Prize shortlist.

The island of Taiwan is located a strait away from China, and is often viewed alongside Japan's Southwest Islands, forming a barrier between the East and South China Seas. The island has endured its fair share of colonisers. *Taiwan Travelogue* is a document of the island in its usual state of cultural osmosis, and how colonialism can permeate every interaction with your environment. The story is set in 1938, in a Taiwan ruled by the Japanese government, a few years before the island is placed under China's administrative control again. Shuang-zi initially posits her Japanese protagonist, Aoyama Chizuko, as an assertive but excitable tourist with an unending passion for food. She has channelled her inquisitive nature into a career as a novelist, which lands her an invitation from the Japanese government to write about the island. The novel is in the form of a travelogue written by this fictional novelist, with footnotes by fictional translators and publishers, as well as King herself.

Speaker vs. listener Chizuko is seemingly aware of her status as a Japanese 'mainlander' in a colony inhabited by

Taiwanese 'islanders', and perceives her love for Taiwanese culture as generosity and openness on her part. She proudly refuses to write propaganda pieces for the Japanese government, and believes her duty as a novelist is to preserve her observations of the island before it is changed forever. She feels she has found her perfect match in Oh Chizuru, the interpreter hired for her by the Japanese government. The two share their first name,



Taiwan Travelogue
Yang Shuang-zi, trs Lin King
Graywolf Press
₹599

but are opposites in many ways – Chizuru is the prudence to Chizuko's folly, the listener to her monologuing speaker, the employee to her employer, the islander to her mainlander. Chizuru allows for all of Chizuko's whims to be fulfilled, specifically those involving travel and food. The meals she prepares are described in breathtaking detail, rarely accompanied by descriptions of the effort she puts in to create these experiences. She speaks perfect Japanese, is eager to quell Chizuko's curiosities about every place and dish they encounter, so that Chizuko can experience the island at exactly the pace she prefers, and says yes to everything she asks – all

but one question: "Could this really be called a friendship?" A majority of the book details Chizuru performing these services for Chizuko, and the latter's perceived romantic tension in their interactions.

Rare chemistry Shuang-zi's prose has a way of capturing what she refers to as Chizuko's 'blind spot' – every observation reflects a foreigner's fascination, an inability to see her surroundings as moulded by horrific circumstances. She asks Chizuru to see sakura blossoms with her, and only upon receiving no response does Chizuko say, "It's brutish, isn't it, to transplant Mainland sakura and force them upon the Island's soil? You think so, too, don't you?" Her superficial love for the island can also be observed in her interactions with Taiwanese people. "Is there some shopping area nearby where the Taiwanese go?" she asks a local ticket collector. Chizuru's poise never betrays the fact that she can see through Chizuko's colonial gaze. Despite these complications and unreliable narrations, the two women do share a rare chemistry. Conversations between them on train rides and in restaurants and tearooms are about as delectable as their menus. Their dynamic poses intriguing questions – can a Mainlander and an Islander be friends? Can you love someone whose stature and upbringing forbid them from viewing you as an equal? Do they only love the virtuosity their kindness reflects on them? *Taiwan Travelogue* does not set out to answer these questions, but rather to reveal them, while paying homage to Taiwan's ever-growing cultural amalgam.

Artist at work

The angst and contradictions of the young, restless and artistically inclined

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In her debut novel, *Good Arguments*, award-winning playwright, writer and artist Deepika Arwind writes about how the liminal zone, "before the becoming... between happenings", is the most precious part of the theatre experience. These are "completely private, completely sacred engines of the imminent

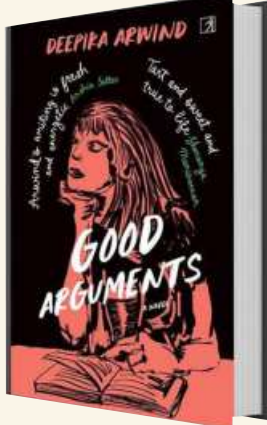
future", she writes, further adding, "Choices are made. Choices are eliminated, worlds and people are propelled into the next second." *Good Arguments* is largely set in this in-between time period, chronicling the becoming of the protagonist, the 20-something Delphi Rodriguez, who is trying to find her footing in the precarious world of theatre, unaided by wealth or social pedigree. The novel,

structurally fragmented, deeply introspective, and very engaging, is populated by an interesting array of characters, almost all of whom Delphi shares a rather complex relationship with.

These include her adoptive mother, Asha, her on-and-off boyfriend Vikrant, her mentor, the noted thespian and stage director Laila Saldana, and her best friend, Sukriti "Su", whose partner she absolutely detests.

Bangalore days As Delphi's story unfolds, we meander into her often-confused mind, watch her negotiate the deeply gendered realities of the world she inhabits, the many hegemonies within creative spaces, and follow her own search for love, friendship, identity and belonging. The novel also dredges up the disbelief and horror of the December 2012 Delhi gang rape and murder, a case that made headlines, led to uprisings all over the country, and brought changes to laws around crimes against women in India. *Good Arguments*, as the name suggests, is an evocative künstlerroman, which raises several relevant questions about women's safety, how

privilege shapes experience, and who gets the space to tell their stories. It succeeds brilliantly in capturing time and place, offering a vibrant portrait of Bengaluru in the early 2000s. A slower, music-filled city still negotiating with its colonial past and disappearing



Good Arguments
Deepika Arwind
Simon & Schuster India
₹599

gardens, where one could still find cheap food and beer and hop into a running autorickshaw. Crammed with insights into music, narrative, and the intersection of politics and art, it examines the theatrical life with nuance, painting it as an ecosystem as multifaceted, dysfunctional and diverse as the larger world it draws from. The best part of the book, however, is Delphi, a character who comes alive on the novel's pages, pulsing with the angst, contradictions, and fragility of the young, restless and artistically inclined. As the author beautifully puts it in the novel, she is "standing on the threshold between beauty and fear... present to life's hand touching my chest. I wanted to touch it back, I just hadn't figured out how". A familiar feeling for nearly anyone who has survived their tumultuous 20s.



GETTY IMAGES

City beneath the concrete

Neha Sinha switches effortlessly between a well-researched field report and an intensely personal memoir

Sunil Rajagopal

Nature writing has always been a niche space. There has been a revival in this genre of late, perhaps driven by the urgency of the pressures placed on the natural world. This writing is often steered by young, passionate authors, who have used it as a tool for conservation. The revival has also seen a change in tonality. The focus has shifted from inaccessible wilderness to the ultra-local and often neglected spaces around where we live. There are also more women and people from varied cultural and scientific backgrounds writing now, not just the adventurer or the explorer. Contemporary nature writing is often as much about inner reflection as it is about the world outside. It is infused with grief over what has been lost, a scientifically based recollection of what remains, and an attempt to reconnect with nature.

In many ways, this is exactly what Neha Sinha's *Wild Capital* (HarperCollins India) does: it richly showcases a side of Delhi unseen by most, switching effortlessly between a well-researched field report and an intensely personal memoir in lyrical language.

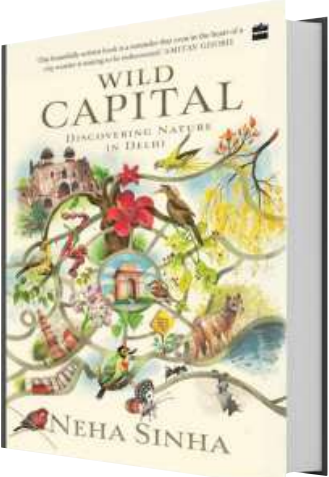
The book is at its best when it immerses the reader in the sensory experience of being outdoors, especially its sonic ambience. It often steps back into 1990s Delhi – a lost world of nature's sacred static, from howling jackals and rain dripping onto the forest floor to insects, owls, and frog calls, now swallowed by the noise of a callous city. As Sinha writes, "What we have now are the clues remnant populations leave us. How important the most basic things are to wildlife – a mature tree, a patch of chemical-free earth, clean amphibian-filled water, dark and damp places where fireflies can light up the way."

A sense of loss threads the different sections together. Sinha tells us not only how the city changed without remembering what is important, but also catalogues what has been lost. Delhi, in the not-too-distant past, harboured healthy populations of wolves, vultures, hog deer, black buck and hyenas, to mention a few.

The writing frequently emerges from walks with friends and colleagues and their own experiences, in a city where, as a young girl, Sinha was advised by her father not to venture out alone. It reflects her own steady learning and deepening appreciation of the natural world – how she once mistook the *Semal* for the *Palash*, how that tree still holds powerful, multi-sensory memories for her, and how it taught her to pursue things that touch lives with meaning.

But not all is lost. Sinha drives home the point that the human experience is not separate from the natural world. The power in her

writing is in making us realise that there is another world out there, a parallel city, if you will, a living and breathing world that is struggling to exist and thrive, hidden beneath the concrete behemoth. The Sanjay Van, the Delhi Ridge, the Mangar Bani, and their residents – the Dhau trees, the summering Pittas, the cuckoos – are all worth protecting. She emphasises that interactions between humans and human-built environments with animals and trees are complex. The conflicts that arise between them require a deeper understanding and not textbook solutions. Cities such as Delhi need to rethink how they design and care for their green spaces, of what it means to be a city. "People have built their houses on leopard land and possess paper declaring it so," she writes. "The leopard has none of these niceties. So it must go." This book records the gentle passing of time in the heart of a most



Wild Capital: Discovering Nature In Delhi
Neha Sinha
HarperCollins India
₹799

urban environment. It is a memoir of collective forgetfulness and of an absence of loss in an unforgiving city, which has allowed so many beautiful things to fade away. Sinha captures this best when she explains the shifting baseline syndrome: when the past is forgotten, the depleted present comes to feel normal, and we may not even realise what we are missing.

The book is also a call to action: to observe, understand, and empathise with the overlooked, to learn to live again with creatures different from us.

Delhi and its history have been written about so many times. And yet, a part of it has never been spoken about. A city's history is incomplete and not separate from the memory of its ecological landscapes – the rivers and rocks and creatures that lived there. Delhi is India's capital, and it is worth remembering that a capital is not just wealth and assets; it is also the land we live on and share.

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Meera Srinivasan
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Several people within and outside Sri Lanka have sought to tell the island's story, including its many troubled chapters in history. But there are always more stories to tell. To appreciate the country's current position, both in terms of geopolitical significance and developmental aspirations, it becomes necessary to understand how the capital Colombo, as we know it today, came to be.

Ajay Kamalakaran's *Colombo: Port of Call* takes us through a range of impressions of Colombo and Sri Lanka, as seen and experienced by 14 international celebrities and travellers, who visited or transited the island at a time when steamships and sea travel were the norm.

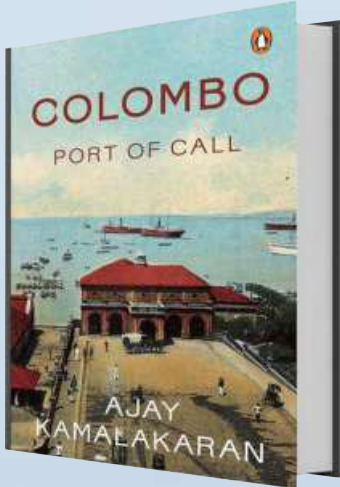
How many of us would have known that Arthur Conan Doyle, the creator of Sherlock Holmes, was a spiritual seeker who chose to write his essays on the subject out of Colombo in 1921? Or heard about Mahatma Gandhi shocking Colombo's elite women by asking them to give up their jewellery and help their "sisters in the plantations", working and living in "hideous conditions", as is mentioned in his secretary Mahadev Desai's book *With Gandhiji in Ceylon* (1928)?

A striking aspect of Kamalakaran's work is the diversity of the sources he draws on – the 'Notes' at the end of the book run into 20 pages, listing

the references he uses – building on visitors' stories to give readers a good glimpse into their time on the island. Reading Kiwi journalist Nelle Scanlan almost a century ago, for instance, offers a fascinating peek into the scenes unfolding at the Colombo Port when Gandhi arrived in Sri Lanka. "Gandhi is the most vital figure in India today," she wrote in 1927, capturing his weight as a freedom fighter, along with the buzz in Ceylon. Scanlan described him as a "man of nearly 60 years, white-clad, with large dark eyes – eyes of a dreamer yet penetrating in their intensity".

In another chapter examining Don Bradman's "brief halts" in Colombo, readers get a glimpse of the cricket craze in Sri Lanka nearly a century ago. Writing in *The Sydney Morning Herald* about this visit in 1930, Bradman notes: "The people were most enthusiastic, and they had infinitely more than a nodding acquaintance with the game." Even today, an imposing full-length picture of Bradman adorns the wall of the pub at Colombo's Tamil Union sports club that adjoins the P. Sara Oval, where Bradman once played.

How many of us would have known that Arthur Conan Doyle, the creator of Sherlock Holmes, was a spiritual seeker who chose to write his essays on the subject out of Colombo in 1921?



Colombo: Port of Call
Ajay Kamalakaran
Penguin Random House India
₹599

American writer Mark Twain, who was on a tour to revive his financial fortunes, arrived in Ceylon on January 13, 1896, as his steamer *Oceana* called at the Colombo port. His arrival was well noticed and recorded, including by *The Ceylon Observer*, which reported on Twain's "unenviable position of not knowing where to lay his head for the night," with all the city's best hotels fully booked at the time. Kamalakaran's little observations are delightful, like his suggestion that the American writer likely saw saris for the first time in Ceylon. "Sometimes a woman's whole dress was but a scarf wound about her person and her head," Twain would write of his visit.

While most visitors would

eventually take to Colombo's charm and its people's warmth, not everyone's first impression was great. Teenaged American dancer Jane Sherman, who was touring Asia with the Denishawn School of Dance for 15 months, stopped in Ceylon after visiting India. She did not enjoy the ferry from Dhanushkodi in Tamil Nadu to Thalaimannar in northern Sri Lanka. "At sunset of the third day, we boarded a boat for Ceylon and arrived, after two hours in a violent lightning storm, to board another ghastly second-class train for Colombo," she wrote to her mother. But her opinion of the island would soon change, as is evident from her subsequent letter to her mother from Kandy, where she speaks of her train journey "through gorgeous tropical scenery – cinnamon and clove trees and tea and palms." She appears to have been relieved after experiencing harsh heat in India. "I've never seen a land with so much water – such a relief after dry, dusty India," she would go on to add in the letter.

The author has put in much effort to capture elements of Colombo's urban history, and more broadly of Sri Lanka, in fair detail, reflecting his own fondness for and enduring interest in the island, which he has been regularly visiting for around two decades now. The pace of the book is uneven, and a little slow at times, especially when Kamalakaran strays into the preceding or subsequent travels of the visitors who broke their journey at the island. It is perhaps deliberate, so the readers can feel the unhurried rhythm of sea travel where Colombo is a stop, and not always the destination.

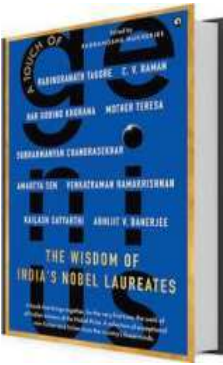


A view of Colombo Port City.
(GETTY IMAGES)

BROWSER

A Touch of Genius
Edited by
Rudrangshu Mukherjee
Aleph
₹1,499

In this book, historian and author Mukherjee brings together the works of all the Indian Nobel Laureates: Rabindranath Tagore, C.V. Raman, Har Gobind Khorana, Mother Teresa, Subrahmanyam Chandrasekhar, among others.



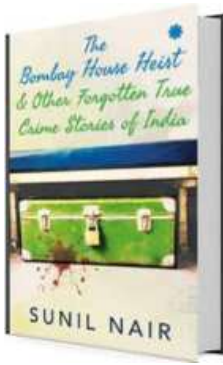
The Good Reporter
Disha Mullick et al.
Simon and Schuster
₹699

This is a collective biography of 'Khabar Lahariya'. Started in 2002 by a group of women from a feudal belt in Uttar Pradesh, the newspaper soon made its way to towns and villages in Bundelkhand. Over the last 24 years, it has shed light on the landscape of rural India.



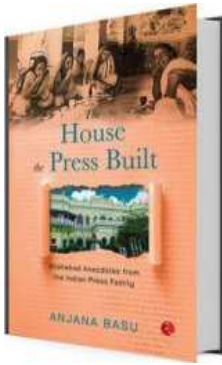
The Bombay House Heist and Other Forgotten True Crime Stories of India
Sunil Nair
Juggernaut
₹499

The Mumbai-based journalist brings together a collection of real-life crime stories, including of the Tata Sons' Bombay House heist.



The House the Press Built: Allahabad Anecdotes from the Indian Press Family
Anjana Basu
Rupa
₹395

Here's a memoir of Chintamani Ghosh, who founded the Indian Press in Allahabad in 1884. He was Rabindranath Tagore's first publisher; the Press published *Gitanjali* in the early 1900s.



HUNGER HAS LEFT THE CHAT

CONTINUED FROM PAGE 1

When it comes to food culture and metabolism, India has a singular signature. Food is community, tradition and lineage, and GLP-1 is generally make a user largely food-proof. As Dhond says, her life has changed inside out. “I was a party girl; a more-than-two-tequilas person. Now, socialising for me is more fitness-related activities or talking and connecting more than eating or drinking.” Adds Mehta, “That one glass of wine is a rarity now.”

Science behind ‘thin-fat Indian’
In a biological sense too, there’s a singularity in India’s diabetes-obesity continuum, and most doctors say GLP-1 drugs are unlikely to crack this complexity. Unlike in many countries around the world, obesity in India is not a strictly metabolic crisis. Our overweight bodies are often a function of genetic mechanisms and foetal undernourishment, besides growing processed diets and resistance to exercise.
Dr. Ravi Sankar Erukulapati, senior consultant endocrinologist, Apollo Hospitals, Jubilee Hills, Hyderabad, points to our “sarcopenic obesity” – low

Guided change

This year, Luke Coutinho, author of two bestsellers and one of India’s most popular and visible lifestyle coaches, started the GLP-1 Drug Lifestyle & Support Program. These are his top suggestions for a smooth journey with GLP-1:

- The focus should be on high-quality fat loss and weight management, not just rapid weight reduction.
- Adequate protein through the day.
- Enough fluids and electrolytes.
- Fibre according to individual needs.
- Smaller, balanced meals if appetite is low.
- Regular strength training and daily movement.
- Adequate, good-quality sleep.
- Close attention to nausea, constipation, reflux, dizziness or under-eating.
- Emotional-psychological life is central, not secondary.



Weightbusters (Clockwise from above) Mukta Dhond; Hansal Mehta and Jitendra Chouksey. (EIMMANUAL YOGINI, SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)

muscle mass and higher fat mass, which worsens insulin resistance. “Added to this is a general lack of awareness. Many people still equate absence of visible obesity with good health, which is not true in the Indian context,” says Dr. Erukulapati.
Dr. Dheeraj Kapoor, head, endocrinology, Kokilaben Dhirubhai Ambani Hospital, Mumbai, adds, “These drugs



are not a quick-fix at a population level. Access, cost and appropriate use will determine impact. Even in the best-case scenario, it will take years before we see a meaningful shift in overall numbers.”
Sarcopenic obesity is endemic in Indian populations – thin arms and forearms, thin legs, narrow chest, but a soft round bulge in the middle; that’s

a common body type among 40-plus Indians. This body profile doesn’t have proven targeted solutions. On the contrary, GLP-1s alchemise one thing in the body exceedingly fast: the shrivelling of muscle mass. Dhond, based on her experience as a Mounjaro user, calls it “death by muscle loss” – the key factor that made her gravitate to a comprehensive lifestyle and exercise protocol.
One Indian diabetologist has been devoted to finding a solution to this problem for more than 30 years. Dr. Chittaranjan Yajnik coined the term ‘thin-fat Indian’ in the early 2000s. In the 1980s, when Dr. Yajnik, weighing 55 kg, was studying at Oxford University, he discovered as part of a research project that his glucose-insulin metabolism was worse than that of his 80 kg English colleague. “I was thin, but had the metabolism of an overweight person,” recalls Dr. Yajnik, 74, director of diabetes unit, KEM Hospital, Pune.
“Indians deposit most fat in and around the abdomen. The highest glucose levels are in those who have low BMI but high waist measurement,” he adds.

The reasons, as Dr. Yajnik found out later, are genetic as well as epigenetic. Exposure to a challenging environment in the womb increases the risk of future diabetes, obesity and heart disease. In India especially, “the heritability of obesity is estimated at 40%-70%. The genetics part influences behaviour around food, such as hunger, satiety, and food reward.”

“Genetics loads the gun, lifestyle pulls the trigger,” adds Dr. Hariharan. According to him, the obesity-related genes cannot be modified – at least not for a long time to come – and lifestyle remains the best “reprogramming tool” for obesity.
Backlash and a fuzzy future
Murmurs of a backlash against the escalated approval of GLP-1s in India went beyond social media, to the Indian judiciary in 2025 – long predating the Indian government’s official guidelines for the usage of these drugs, which came out in the first week of April. The guidelines specify that to be on any GLP-1 drug, generic or the originals, a



Genetics loads the gun; lifestyle pulls the trigger... The heritability of obesity is estimated at 40-70% [in India]. The genetics part influences behaviour around food, such as hunger, satiety, and food reward

DR. RAMESH HARIHARAN
CEO & co-founder, Strand Life Sciences, Bengaluru



[For a fulfilling GLP-1 journey], you need to know how to thrive. How to eat, think, live and most importantly, how to change your relationship with food

DR. ALEXANDRA SOWA
Internal medicine and obesity expert, New York, and author of *The Ozempic Revolution*



Newer agents in this family, and dual incretin drugs such as tirzepatide, have changed the conversation because, for the first time, we have medicines that can produce meaningful and, sometimes, dramatic weight reduction. American Diabetes Association guidelines now place weight management centrally in diabetes care, and GLP-1-based therapy is among the preferred approaches when weight loss is a major goal

DR. DAVID CHANDRY
Director, endocrinology and diabetology, Sir H.N. Reliance Foundation Hospital, Mumbai

lifestyle pulls the trigger,” adds Dr. Hariharan. According to him, the obesity-related genes cannot be modified – at least not for a long time to come – and lifestyle remains the best “reprogramming tool” for obesity.

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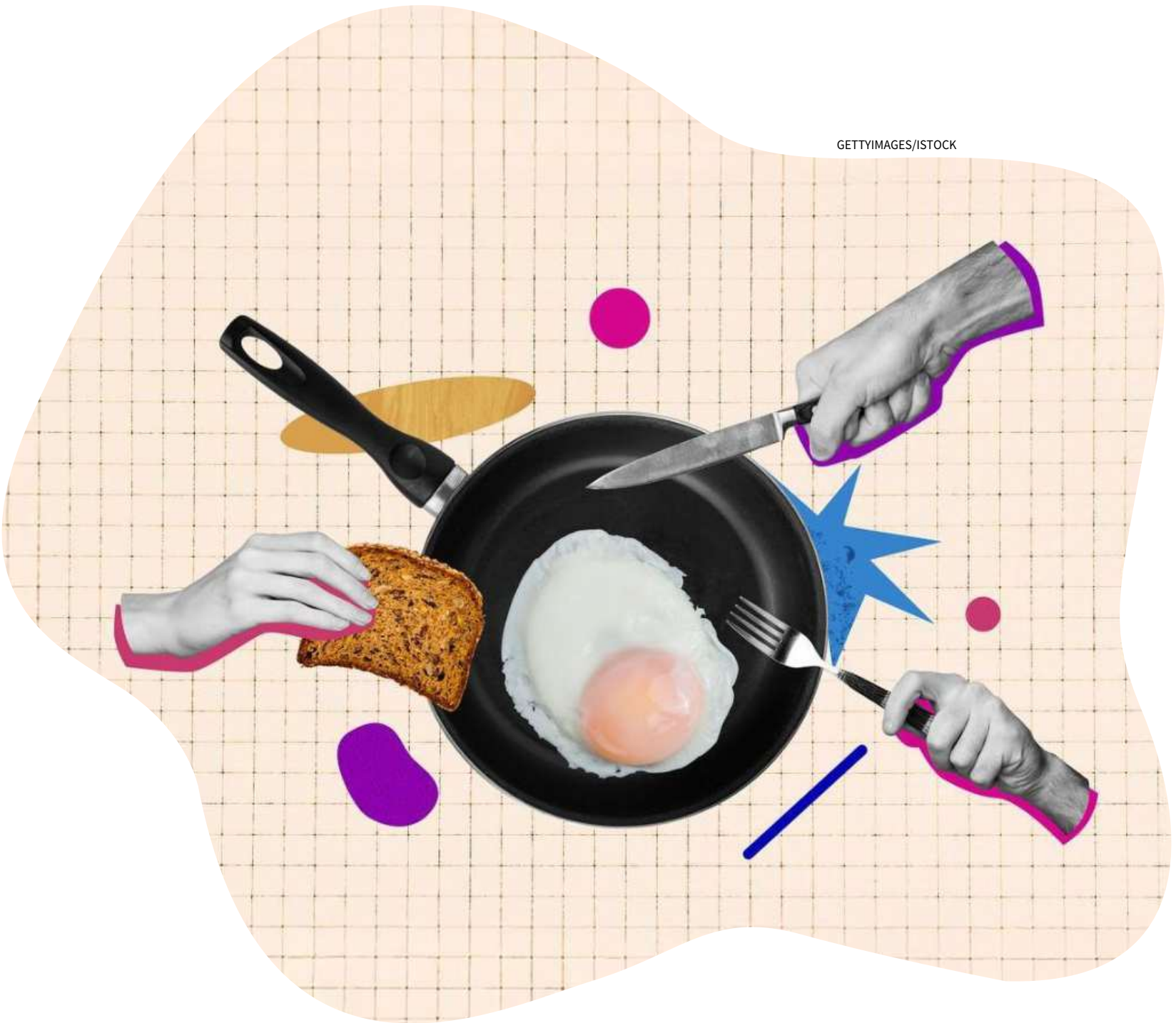
prescription from an endocrinologist, a cardiologist or an internal medicine specialist is essential. It also instructs drug manufacturers to stop any marketing that encourages unsupervised use.

The biggest opposition was in the form of a PIL, submitted to the Delhi High Court in May 2025 by Jitendra Chouksey, fitness evangelist and founder at Pune-based preventive health company FITTR. “I felt it was needed because of the fast approvals these drugs got, and the way it is being used not just in hospitals, but in wellness clinics. I had many clients who were on it. The muscle mass loss it causes can be dangerous and as soon as you stop the medicine, the weight comes back with a vengeance,” says Chouksey, 40.

It’s unclear what weight-loss drugs will ultimately do to human metabolism and the human body. As a market, it is gold rush now, trickling down even to aesthetic clinics. At Klarity Health Clinic in Delhi, for example, a Mounjaro Bride Package comes at ₹1.10 lakh for 12 sessions. India’s GLP-1 brides are a swelling demographic.

Every other day, there is news from the U.S. about the effect of GLP-1s beyond weight and metabolism – to additions, menopausal health, autoimmune diseases, and even mental health. In the Indian context, given our diversity and unique obesity signature, the promise is lofty but conditional, at best. Time will tell if Ozempic really changes humanity’s attempt at optimum health in an overburdened planet.

The writer is a Mumbai-based journalist and health advocate, and behind the preventive health and longevity media IP @the_slow_fix.

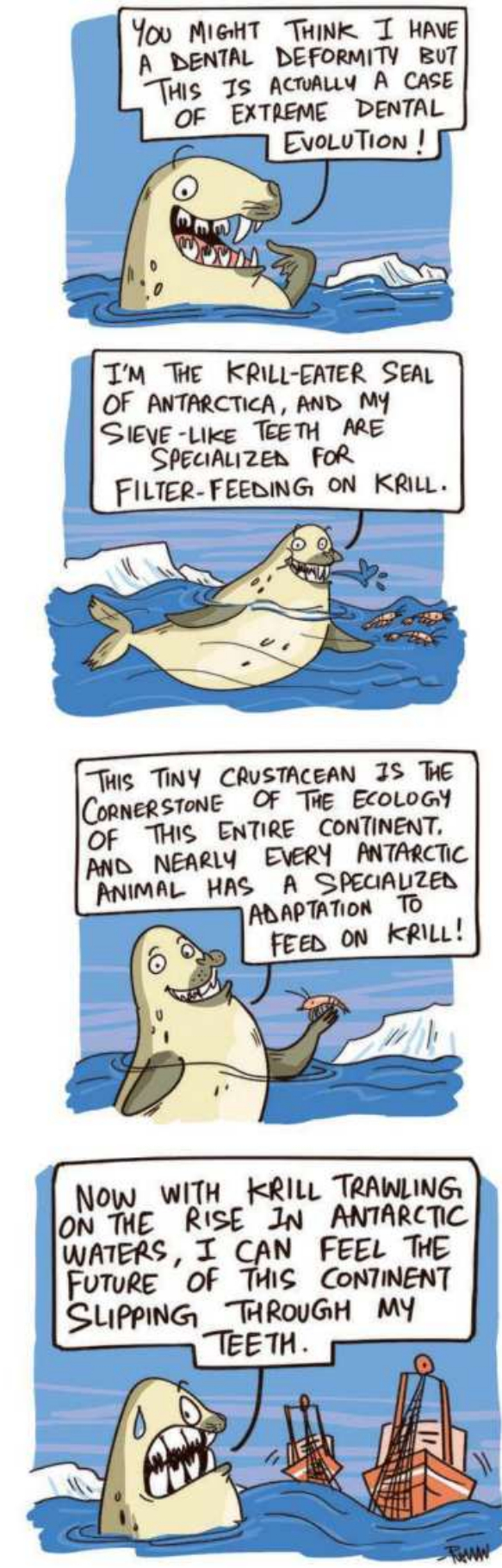


Celebrity nutritionist Rujuta Diwekar’s advice has split the health community, and the problem of the catchy reel is far bigger than it seems

PROTEIN PANIC OR NECESSARY SHIFT?

GREEN HUMOUR

Rohan Chakravarty



Rainbow garnish (Clockwise from right) Chef Preeti Mistry; books about food; coconut crab crumpets by Gurdeep Loyal; and food writer Gurdeep Loyal. (ANANDA NALE, JAY WALKER, SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)

Sudha G. Tilak

It begins, as many food memories do, in a kitchen. In the recently released biography *Chapal Rani: The Last Queen of Bengal*, author Sandip Roy recalls how Chapal Bhaduri, the legendary female impersonator of Bengali jatra folk theatre, lingered in his mother’s kitchen.

Not playing rough with the para (neighbourhood) boys outside, but drawn instead to the rhythms of domesticity: the stirring pot, the clink of bangles against a chopping blade, the quiet choreography of care. Food, for Chapal, was inheritance.

“Chapal is the living archive and the last custodian of the recipes his mother made. His mother was an immense part of him,” says Roy. “Her recipes and her food were how he held on to her.” Later, in a lover’s home, Chapal slipped almost instinctively into domestic roles of cooking, caring, feeding, mirroring the very femininity he performed on stage. The kitchen, in this sense, became another stage. Even as the vocabulary of queer food in India begins to take shape, Roy suggests it has long existed as lived experience.

Roy’s portrait of Chapal is not just about performance but about absence of vocabulary and labels. “He didn’t have the language we have now – of queer food or being gay,” Roy says. “But he lived it.” The recipes Roy includes are homespun dishes like mixed *achaar* and *machhi mulo* (fish with radish). “Including recipes in Chapal’s story was an organic way to tell his life.” As he served his savoury *papaya habus* with a flourish, Chapal’s sister would tease him that his cooking was over the top “like his jatra”.

Queer food is not a cuisine. It is a way of understanding food through lived experience and where cooking carries stories of identity, longing, secrecy, pleasure and belonging.

When he was a student in the U.S. in the late 90s and early



2000s, Roy remembers that queer Indian gatherings often centred around food. “The potluck dinners gave you a reason to be both queer and *desi* at the same time.” At a Diwali night, you were just another *desi*; in a gay bar, simply queer. But around Indian food, both identities found their meeting point.

The shelf life

Food writer Vikram Doctor says, “Food has always been a binding force for the queer community, in India and elsewhere. Queer food books would be a valuable addition in reflecting that.”

The modern grammar of queer food writing was shaped by *The Man Who Ate Too Much* (2020) by John Birdsall, his landmark biography of James Beard, the gourmand whose legacy lives on in the James Beard Awards, often described as the Oscars of the American food world.

Birdsall placed queerness not at the margins of culinary history but at its centre. Beard’s appetite, ambition, secrecy and loneliness were inseparable from his legacy. Cooking became a way to feed others while hiding oneself.



QUEERNESS ON MY PLATE

Food binds India and more so its queer community, as memory, resistance and belonging. An uptick in books on queer food shows why these stories matter

That insight cracked open an entire genre. Queer food writing since then has not been about rainbow garnish; it has been about the excavation of selfhood and sexuality.

Elsewhere, younger writers bring a lighter, playful energy. London-based creator Dominic Franks turns everyday baking into irreverent storytelling in *Upside Down Cooking* (2025), flipping classics like spanakopita into tray-baked surprises.

Similarly flamboyant is *Dragtails* (2023), a cocktail book inspired by drag royalty that treats drinks as theatrical performances. Alice Wood and Greg Bailey’s book offers a salute to the gloriously extravagant Grand Maha-Raja, a showy cocktail of sambuca, Grand Marnier, brandy and lemonade, created by drag performer Raja Gemini, who describes a good cocktail as “a tool to take a performance to another level of elegance”.

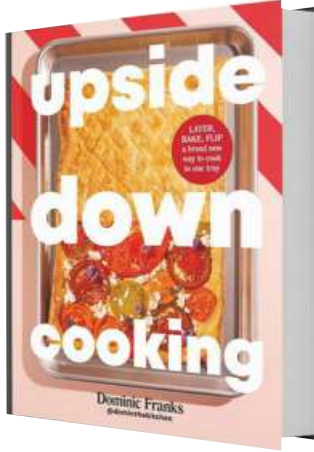
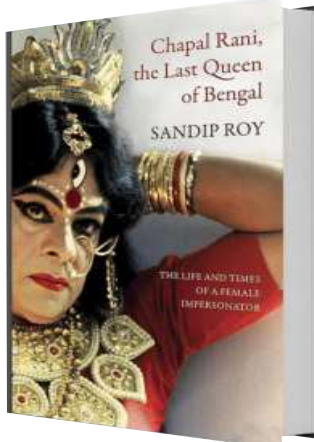
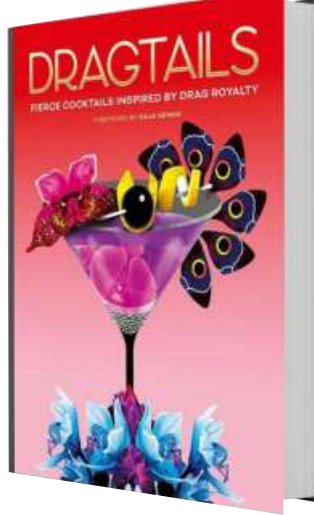
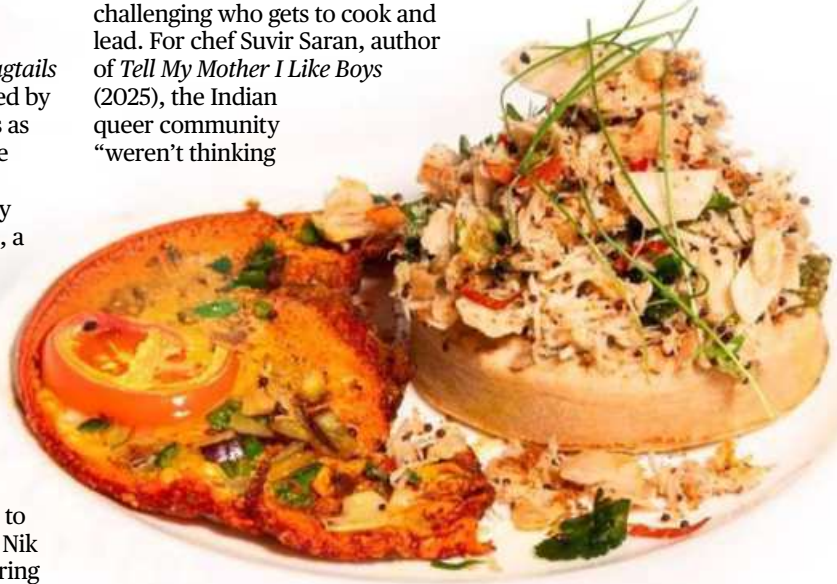
Today, these narratives are moving from private kitchens to public platforms. Writers like Nik Sharma and Gurdeep Loyal bring

queer perspectives into mainstream food writing, even when not always explicitly labelled. Loyal describes his recipes as “bravely indulgent and liberated from narratives of shame and self-denial,” where his Indianness and Britishness co-exist fully on the plate.

California-based Chef Preeti Mistry too redefines the kitchen as a space of visibility and assertion, challenging who gets to cook and lead. For chef Suvir Saran, author of *Tell My Mother I Like Boys* (2025), the Indian queer community “weren’t thinking

about queerness and food; we were living, breathing and bound by food”.

As a student in a South Delhi school, Saran recalls planning meals, setting tables with inventive napkin rings, and arranging flowers – “borrowing my mother’s *ikebana* skills” – long before he had the language to call it queer aesthetics.



Queer food, then, is not about invention. It is about reimagining.

Tasting menu

In India, queer-led pop-ups and supper clubs are often folded into a crowded food culture. Unlike in the West, where queer-dining spaces are explicitly marketed, here they are subtler and embedded within the chaos of cities like Kolkata or Mumbai.

And yet, the impulse remains the same: to gather, to feed, to belong.

Saran recalls that Veda, the Delhi restaurant he partnered on with the late designer Rohit Bal, embodied a queer, bordello-like aesthetic that was opulent, theatrical, unapologetic. That same energy can be felt at Delhi’s Depot 48, where drag nights and classical music co-exist. Vicky Narula, co-founder of Depot 48, says, “We are reclaiming the kitchen as a space of radical joy,” and Indian queer food books to be a great add-on to queer literature.

Anil Pradhan and Andronicus Adeti in ‘Achiari Anecdotes: Exploring Queer Food Cultures in Indian Kitchens’ (a chapter from *Queering Nutrition and Diets: LGBTQ+ Reflections on Food through Art*, 2023) write about how food is queered through memory, intimacy and camaraderie, whether by cooking for partners, reworking traditional dishes, or blurring rigid food categories. A dish like ‘Paneer Rituparno’, for instance, playfully challenges culinary orthodoxy while playing on the name of the late Bengali filmmaker Rituparno Ghosh.

Thus, the recipes that emerge from queer spaces and the books are as varied as the lives behind them: *paan* dipped in condensed milk and toasted coconut. A dosa waffle. A saffron custard tart with candied fennel seeds.

A miso-masala fried chicken sandwich. A sharp, spicy ginger, chilli and vodka Monicaidati. Or simply, *roshogolla* with extra syrup.

And, sometimes, it is quieter still – two people, a biographer (Roy) and a queen (Chapal Bhaduri), sharing *cha* in clay cups and *biskoot* in a shadowy room in North Kolkata.

The writer is the author of Temple Tales and translator of Hungry Humans.

Sumana Mukherjee

There’s a war underway. No, not the one on your television screens. This one’s playing out on your phones, and the target is, of all things, your protein intake.
For those who don’t live their lives online, here’s the executive summary. On April 1, celebrity health and wellness influencer Rujuta Diwekar posted a reel pegged ostensibly to a common predicament of the older of her 1.8 million Instagram followers: their children were urging them to include more protein in their diet. In a line that evokes the no-utensils-no-opinion stand on abortion adopted by pro-choice advocates, Diwekar said they should ignore their sons’ advice on food, including protein, collagen, creatine, omega-3, and prebiotics, till such time they were cooking meals for multiple people every day. “*Bachha hain, bada hone do* [He’s a child, let him grow up],” she signs off.

If the intent was to trigger multiple groups with a single post – the algorithms of social media reward provocative posts with higher engagement, which translates into more followers and, consequently, greater reach/influence, and therefore higher economic benefits via brand deals – Diwekar had hit the sweet spot. With more than 1.8 million views and 10,000-odd shares at the time of writing, her highest numbers in the current calendar year, it can be safely said, Diwekar had “gone viral”.

Within days, if not hours, the pushback started: counter-reels from doctors, qualified nutritionists, trainers, fitness coaches. Television personality Mini Mathur, who recently reinvented herself as a certified women’s health coach and founded Paustive, an initiative focused on menopause education and care, wrote on Diwekar’s post: “You are a beacon in nutrition... but when YOU tell women their nutritional needs come last... you



Screen grabs from Rujuta Diwekar’s (left) and Nandita Iyer’s Instagram videos.



are putting us decades back. When a son tells his mom she needs evidence based nutritional requirements... we should encourage the debate.”

Not a joke

“I wondered for a second if [Diwekar’s post] was an April fool’s joke,” says Nandita Iyer. She holds an MBBS with a fellowship in applied nutrition, is a health coach and author, most recently, of *No Gods, No Gurus: A Radical Guide to Your Wellbeing* (Bloomsbury, December 2025). Iyer (@saffrontrail), who upholds nutrition, movement, sleep and stress management as the four pillars of healthcare, put out her rebuttal reel to her 220k followers a few days later, taking umbrage especially with the dismissal of the younger generation, and backing up her points with peer-reviewed studies.

The complication, as Iyer points out, is that on social media, short-cuts – read catchy reels with easy or no-work solutions – will always fly higher than nuanced advisories. In India, battling related issues ranging from undernutrition to obesity, the fallout can be especially unkind.

It is a problem that the National Institute of Nutrition (NIN) in Hyderabad, which works under the Indian Council of Medical

‘Critically assess information’

To be fair, Diwekar, who rose to celebrity as trainer to some of Bollywood’s finest, has a post-graduate qualification in sports science and nutrition from SNDT College, Mumbai (also attended summer school on ‘Future of Foods’ at the University of Potsdam, Germany).

Her posts are frequently a mash of sound common sense (carry more underwear in perimenopause), traditional remedies (eat *shepu*, or dill, for hair health) and local interpretations of established trends, such as superfoods (*neem* chutney).

Each of them finds resonance and engagement with hundreds of followers every day, which often translates into them taking up the cudgels on Diwekar’s behalf should she be perceived to be under attack – cue, the protein post. Iyer and other rebutters are finding this out, as they get labelled anti-India, anti-ancestral knowledge and the like. (Diwekar herself could not be reached for this story, despite multiple efforts.)

Between the binaries, though, Dr. Gavaravarapu acknowledges that even the conventionally educated may be nutritionally illiterate. To that end, ICMR-NIN has partnered with UNICEF in Let’sFixOurFood, a skill-based nutrition literacy programme. Plus, they have just completed the legwork on the first-ever survey across a sample size of 2,00,000 in all States and Union territories for a fine-tuned sense of what India eats and its nutritional issues.

“By the end of the year, we look to have actionable information,” he says. “It will inform policy and also our posts.”

Till then, he suggests to critically assess information one encounters on social media. Or, if that’s too hard, use judgment on the influencers to follow.

The writer and editor is based in Bengaluru.

Dear readers, and just like that, it is April. January, February and March have all just vanished into the past. And yet, some of us still have Christmas decorations hanging here and there.

And on a daily basis, our spouses beg us: “Please pack away these Christmas decorations! Do you not have any shame??? How many times have I told you? Guests have started giggling to themselves. Easter has also gone. Jesus has been born, and grown old, and died, and then returned from death, and then gone back to his father. And we still have a large penguin dressed like the Pope on top of the TV? WHY??”

This is just a fictional example. Not a true story. Also, I will do it next week. But this topic of time has been on my mind recently.

The other day, I was sitting with some friends in a cafe and discussing current affairs. And the main topic was the Artemis mission to the moon by NASA. (Hopefully, the astronauts have returned safely by the time you are reading this.)

We discussed Artemis with great enthusiasm. Reader, not since the 1980s have I felt such thrills for space travel. Of course, there have been numerous instruments sent to space, and thrilling photographs, a fantastic comet landing, and the International Space Station is now such a quotidian thing that we treat it as some kind of WeWork in the sky.

But, a moon mission? How exciting. And then, one of my friends said something. “God. What a golden age the 1960s were! Such an exciting time. I wish we were living in the 1960s!” Readers, my immediate instinct was to hit him across the face with a stale croissant. But I controlled myself. “Oh, really?” I said. “The space race was exciting but what about all the other things?” My friend laughed and laughed. He took his phone, did finger-Mohiniyattam for two seconds and then showed me a photo. “Look! This is what Bombay looked like in the 60s. And now look at this? It is Bangalore! And now look at this photo? It is London. Look how clean and



TRICKTIONARY EPISODE 29

QUIT BEING DELULU

Why do young people living the good times sit and reminisce about the past?

magnificent and classy and shiny the city was.” Friends, please keep in mind that this friend was born in the 80s. Immediately, I took his phone and some finger-dancing later, I opened the Wikipedia page for the 1960s. Look, I told him. Look at all the good

things. But also look at all the wars and earthquakes and assassinations and disease and famines. And I made an impassioned speech about the misplaced tendency to glorify the past. The speech was very well-received by all the patrons of the cafe, because my friends had left 15 minutes earlier.

Dear readers, these days nostalgia is out of control. Everywhere you look, people are yearning for a glorious past. Some yearn for the Bollywood of the 70s. Others yearn for the innocent days before COVID-19. Still others yearn for the glory days of Mohenjodaro and Harappa.

And there are even people who yearn for the specific 2003-04 period when Arsenal won the Premier League undefeated. Foolish people.

Shall I tell you why I think so many people are nostalgic? Because they always assume that in their vision of the romantic past, they always had the cool job, the luxury lifestyle, the gala timepass. Always the pharaoh, never the mason. Always the mogul, never the marble cutter. Always the billionaire, never the serf.

I hate it. And I especially I hate it when young people sit and reminisce about the past. Bloody fools! You are living in good times. Have you considered doing something to make these times better? So that your grandchildren will look back and say wonderful things about the 2020s?

Instead, here you are sitting and fondly remembering things that did not happen. There should be a word for this. And that word is: yesterdaze.

Example sentence: Priya suffered from mild yesterdaze whenever

Yesterdaze /ˈjɛstədəɪz/ *noun*
Definition: A delusional state of romanticising historical periods one never experienced, characterised by selective amnesia about the hardships, injustices and inconveniences of the past while fantasising about having occupied positions of privilege one almost certainly would not have held.
Related forms:
Yesterdazed (*adjective*): In a state of yesterdaze; romanticising the past.
Yesterdazing (*verb*): The act of indulging in nostalgic fantasies about eras one never lived through.
Yesterdazer (*noun*): A person who chronically suffers from yesterdaze.

she saw old Bollywood films, imagining herself as a glamorous heroine in a flowing sari, until her grandmother gently reminded her that in those days, she would more likely be hand-washing the saris for six hours every Sunday and ironing them with a coal-heated iron in 40-degree heat.

Have you spent any time yesterdazing? Does it make you nostalgic for the days when people didn't yesterdaze?



Sidin Vadukut helps early stage companies communicate better. He blogs at www.whatay.com.

GOREN BRIDGE

Which game?

Both vulnerable. West deals

Bob Jones

North did not know how many spades to bid at his second turn, so he made a cue bid to see if he could learn anything more from his partner. South felt his two kings, opposite North's strong bidding, warranted a game bid and he made the good bid of three no trump. North, with his flat hand, saw no reason to disturb

that contract and passed. Nice bidding. South won the opening club lead in hand with the 10 and led a low spade. West played the king and South won with dummy's ace. The jack of spades from dummy was won by West with the queen, and West cashed the ace of clubs and continued with the queen to South's king. That set up West's long clubs, but West had no entry to enjoy them. South

knew that West had no entry so he could afford to play a heart to dummy's 10. When that forced the king from East, South claimed 10 tricks. Note that a four-spade contract by North-South would have failed, probably by two tricks after a heart lead. Declarer could hold it to down one, but he would have to give up his reasonable chance to make it by taking the heart finesse.

NORTH
♠ A J 10 6
♥ A Q 10
♦ A Q J
♣ J 4 3

WEST
♠ K Q 7
♥ J 8 4
♦ 8 7
♣ A Q 9 8 7

EAST
♠ 5 3
♥ K 7 6 5 3
♦ 10 9 6 3 2
♣ 6

SOUTH
♠ 9 8 4 2
♥ 9 2
♦ K 5 4
♣ K 10 5 2

The bidding:
WEST 1♣
NORTH Dbl
EAST Pass
SOUTH 3NT
All pass

Opening lead: Eight of ♣

QUIZ

Easy like Sunday morning

What has April 12 ever given us?



A vaccine developed by Dr. Jonas Salk in 1955 was a major breakthrough in medical history. (GETTY IMAGES)

Berty Ashley

Born on April 12, 1885, R.D. Banerji was an officer of the Archaeological Survey of India in the Western Circle. In 1919, he visited a site, identified a flint scraper, and realised its antiquity. His report led to the excavation of which city that had been buried for nearly 3,700 years?

On April 12, 1892, George Blickensderfer obtained a patent for his invention. It became a big hit as it was a portable version of the large, bulky machines made by Remington. What machine was this, which was a huge help to authors?

On April 12, 1926, this gentleman released his first

film as director. Titled *The Pleasure Garden*, it was a silent drama about a troubled relationship between two chorus girls. The arrival of a ghost towards the end gives us an early insight into the style of which iconic director?

On April 12, 1954, Bill Haley & His Comets recorded their song *Rock Around the Clock*. It sparked a craze and helped launch a new genre of music, making Haley a pioneer. What genre is this that is mentioned in many song titles to this day?

On April 12, 1955, a vaccine developed by Dr. Jonas Salk was declared safe, effective, and potent. This historic moment marked a major breakthrough in the fight against a disease that

could cause paralysis. What was the vaccine for?

On April 12, 1961, this cosmonaut became the first human to travel into outer space. Sixty-five years later, on April 6, 2026, four astronauts set the record as the farthest-travelling humans. Who was this pioneering spaceman?

Born on April 12, 1961, Lisa Gerrard is an Australian singer known for her unique singing style, often described as 'ethereal wailing.' After collaborating with Hans Zimmer on a 2000 film – for which she received an Oscar nomination – the 'wailing woman' sound became ubiquitous in Hollywood. What movie about a Roman family was this?

On April 12, 1990, this anime TV series based on the children's books by Tove Jansson was first broadcast. The white, round fairy-tale characters with large snouts (who are not hippos but trolls) became a worldwide sensation. What characters are these?

On April 12, 2009, the U.S. Navy rescued Captain Richard Phillips after a five-day standoff off the Somali coast, following the hijacking of the MV Maersk Alabama. This incident and the film that followed brought new attention to what ancient maritime profession?

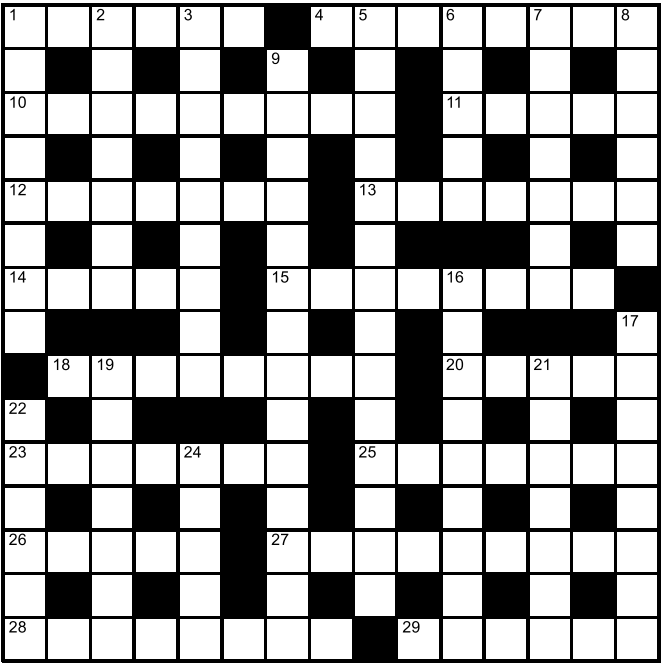
On April 12, 2023, New York City appointed Kathleen Corradi as its first-ever __ czar. As director of __ mitigation, her job was to decrease its population by working with various departments. With a multi-million dollar budget, what title did she hold in the state government?

A molecular biologist from Madurai, our quizmaster enjoys trivia and music, and is working on a rock ballad called 'Coffee is a Drink, Kaapi is an Emotion'. @bertyashley

1. Mohenjodaro
2. Portable Typewriter
3. Alfred Hitchcock
4. Rock & Roll
5. Polio
6. Yuri Gagarin
7. Gladiator
8. Moon
9. Pirates
10. Rat mitigation

Answers

THE HINDU SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 51 (Set by Arden)



- Across**
1 Day full of ideology leads to unhappiness (6)
4 Perhaps built as to describe new Byzantium (8)
10 Rode an offender? (9)
11 Plot takes an odd turn - do follow (5)
12 Desert dweller returned to a legendary town (7)
13 Cocktail with a neighbour shows Indian spirit (7)
14 Cherries on icing encapsulate boom, in a way (5)
15 Working on Goa and a place in New York state (8)
18 Boast about friend to intimidate (8)
20 After a month one returns to take head of clan to the holy city (5)
23 Church goes over lists to purify the place (7)
25 Can't Sue become crazy? (7)
26 Detonated some, back in August (5)
27 Boundaries vital to get to eighty (9)
28 Can a graduate accept mistake? That'll be capital! (8)
29 Separate, withstand a scoundrel (6)

- Down**
1 Crestfallen to see the feathers being shed (8)
2 Rockstar's quiet with woman, strangely (7)
3 Cherub-like one calling out to suppress echo (9)

- 5 Allowed to enter wild forest - to work using internal energy is a brainwave (6,2,6)
6 Room at the top for open lattice (5)
7 Land around a college is invigorating (7)
8 Dangerous to allow and stop short (6)
9 Amateur makes your fielders to spread out (2-2-10)
16 Maybe China keeps it in service to block a river (9)
17 So long as there is charge on the spa (8)
19 Authorise inclusion in two articles written in an ancient language (7)
21 Mountain goat found in such a moist place (7)
22 Popular at home taking care of nice interiors (6)
24 First go in with nothing on showing butt (5)

SOLUTION NO. 50

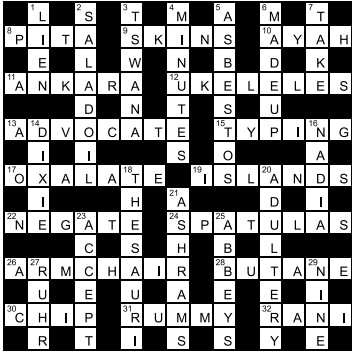




ILLUSTRATION: SREEJITH R. KUMAR

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How dramatically things have changed in the world of telecommunications. Today, practically everyone carries a mobile phone with access to countless apps and social media platforms. In the early 1980s, when I had returned home after completing medical school, landlines were the only mode of telephone communication. Cellphones had not yet arrived. After a few months on the waiting list, we were finally granted the much-coveted telephone connection. On “D-day”, the technician arrived with his tools – and an air of self-importance – to install it. He set up one of those black, heavy rotary-dial machines. Residential phones were still something of a novelty in our town. Ours was the first in our circle of friends and relatives, and excitement buzzed through our home and spilled into the neighbourhood. In the initial weeks, there were hardly any incoming calls. We often found ourselves hoping someone – anyone – would ring. On the rare occasion the phone rang, everyone at home would scramble to answer it. We also made outgoing calls at the slightest excuse. News of our “phone” spread quickly among neighbours and relatives. In the evenings, visitors would drop in to call their loved ones in faraway places. My mother would serve them tea and snacks. These phone calls became social catalysts for genuine bonding. Our guests would often leave with promises to return soon. But when the phone

Dialling in to landline nostalgia

It fostered a human connectedness even with all its clunky simplicity

bills started creeping up, we tried dropping gentle hints about the public call offices nearby – only to be waved off with, “Oh, they’re too inconvenient.”

Buzz in the neighbourhood
Our neighbours, not to be left out, began distributing our number freely. Soon, we started receiving calls for them – often at odd hours. Typically, the caller would ask, “Who’s speaking?”, and I would be tempted to reply, “It’s you, Sir/Madam, who’s talking.” Instead, I politely announced my name, only to be met with a demand: “Who are you?”

Fetching neighbours to attend their calls became my duty. They would ask me to tell the caller they were “on their way”. Sometimes, I even got an earful from callers for the delay. The calls varied from personal matters to idle gossip. We would offer to step out to give them privacy, but they would gesture to us to stay. My gentle reminders to keep it short often went unheard – by ears and by phones. Some lingered after their call, offering a synopsis of the conversation, to which we would respond with a polite murmur. Every now and then, a woman would show up claiming to “service” the phone. She would do a cursory check, dust it, and use a stingy amount of cleaning fluid. The stained cloth she used never seemed to change. Before leaving, she would assure us that the phone was clean – until her next visit. Of course, the phone would return to its full microbial glory after the very next call. Amid all these light-hearted moments, the phone proved invaluable in serious situations. During a natural disaster at a relative’s workplace, it helped us confirm their safety and reassure the rest of the family. A few years later, we upgraded to a push-button model. My mother would call her friends under the pretext of “casual chats” just to slip in the news of our sleek new phone. Even our domestic help, who made full use of the phone, proudly brought her friends over to show it off. The original phone remains in our home to this day. It is cherished as a symbol of a simpler era. While today’s gadgets enable instant electronic connectivity, the kind of human connectedness that the landline fostered – with all its clunky simplicity – may never quite be matched.

Walk to work, discover many hidden gems

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I walk to work every day. It is hardly a kilometre from home, a 10-minute stroll, 15 if I take it easy. Yet I seldom come across anyone else covering even this short distance on foot. Most schoolchildren are shuttled in vans or deposited at the gate by parents on scooters, their sleepy heads nodding, their school bags seeming almost heavier than their small frames. Now and then, someone I know slows their vehicle beside me and offers a lift. I smile, shake my head, and thank them. They drive off, a little puzzled perhaps. A passing bus sometimes eases its pace, its conductor waving at me to hop in. Even autorickshaw drivers pause briefly, certain I must be waiting for a ride. I wave them on too.

The irony is that walking is not always the safer choice. The roadside can be a treacherous stretch, full of ankle-twisting dips and mystery materials. Plastic wrappers flutter like fallen feathers. Pebbles sit about like small traps. And occasionally there is the grimmer sight of a lifeless crow beneath an electric line, or the half-eaten remains of a rodent left behind by scavenger birds in a hurry. But walking gives me something no ride ever could.

There is this lottery vendor at the corner. In the early days he would thrust a hopeful fan of tickets toward me. Now, having understood that I am not the gambling kind, he offers something rarer. A warm, knowing smile. The tea stall owner near the alley raises his hand in greeting, even though I have never once stopped for a cup. His smile too is unconditional. There is something deeply human in this repeated seeing. Faces become familiar not through conversation, but through quiet recognition. And then there is the sweat. A light dampness across the back. A small tingle at the neck. It is not unpleasant. It tells me I have moved, I have stretched, I am awake. By the time I reach my desk, I am already charged, as if the short walk has switched something on inside me. Walking to work may not be fashionable, or fast, or even entirely safe. But for me, it is a ritual. A small act of resistance against the rush. A daily communion with a city that still remembers how to smile.

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During mountain treks, one keeps seeing tourists feeding wild monkeys with everything from bananas to packaged food. The easy availability of nutrient-dense and tasty food around the trek paths of tourists seems to have drawn the monkeys away from their natural food sources in the interiors of the mountainous forests. An unpleasant consequence has been a marked increase in the number of monkey attacks on humans. Those monkeys do not seem to fear humans now. Children and women clad in saris seem to be particularly vulnerable. I don’t know what makes monkeys attack sari-clad humans. During a recent trek, I

Stop giving food to animals in the wild

This makes them stressed, aggressive, intensifies human-wildlife conflict



ISTOCK/GETTY IMAGES

told one monkey-feeder that it is unwise to feed animals in the wild because this behaviour has been shown to increase human-animal conflicts. But like many animal lovers, he seemed dismissive of human concerns. “You may keep your views to yourself...” he said angrily. I explained, “These are not

my views. They are based on scientific research on animal behaviour. You can google the scientific articles on the subject. Don’t just get angry.” As I started walking away, he said, “I don’t care.” Please know and inform others that it is bad to feed animals in the wild. It makes them less fearful of humans, more stressed and aggressive, thereby increasing human-animal conflicts. Moreover, human foods are generally inappropriate for animals in the wild. Easy food also contributes to unnatural population growth. When they don’t have to expend energy looking for food, they expend that energy mating or quarrelling. Kindness towards animals is certainly a good thing. But that kindness must care to see if it is inadvertently harming the interests of both animals and humans.

Going back to childhood haunts

Revisiting them helps reconnect with lost youth and acts as a tonic to elders

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Few can resist the overpowering lure of an old childhood haunt. Somehow it holds a strong emotional attachment for most of us. Indeed, the very prospect of returning to one’s “roots”, as it were, enthuses one considerably, making one look forward to it eagerly. Recently, I precisely did that. I visited a much-loved but long-forgotten retreat on the outskirts of Munnar – a secluded rainbow-trout fishing nook that I had



ISTOCK/GETTY IMAGES

frequented as a boy in the 1950s. Though now teeming with thousands of tourists (rather than trout!), this little sylvan hangout, quite incredibly, had not changed at all.

Solid, stoic
The fast-flowing stream that fed the Madupatty dam reservoir back then still gushed and froathed furiously under the bridge. The huge boulders from which I had fished nearly 70 years ago still stood

there quite unimaginably – solid, Sphinx-like, and stoic. So did the big jungle tree, now skeletal, gnarled and leafless – a silent sentinel and witness to the many frisky fish that had fought free after being hooked, much to my acute dismay. These hoary landmarks seemed to welcome me back warmly. I stood on the bridge and gazed down at the rushing water, entranced, as memories from the distant past jostled with each other. I could well picture the many pink-flanked rainbows I had caught back then, thrashing about wildly on the grass. I could also visualise old Kodangi, my grizzled mentor, puffing away at a beedi as he skillfully cast his line out, his rod arcing sharply when he hooked a trout. A veteran angler, he always caught far more fish than I did, much to my envy. Trout fishing was then – and still is – a passion for me. It enlivened my boyhood immeasurably, instilling in me the need for infinite patience – a

valuable trait that has stood me in good stead in my adult life. And, of course, besides whiling away heavenly hours in that halcyon haunt with my siblings, we did get to relish the gastronomic delights of fried rainbow trout, a scrumptious dish. The tryst inevitably stoked other fond memories too. Remembering my two late brothers – very much a part of those fun-filled fishing trips – emotion left my eyes misty. Their lively presence had buoyed my spirits, hardening my determination not to return empty-handed, even if I had to fish till late in the evening. And my unflagging patience usually paid off. Revisiting old haunts to reconnect with one’s long-forgotten youth is a tonic to many elders like me. Personally speaking, it turned out to be quite therapeutic, spiritually uplifting and rejuvenating besides dispelling drooping spirits. Overall, it did have a positively soothing effect on my mind.



FEEDBACK

Letters to the Magazine can be e-mailed separately to mag.letters@thehindu.co.in by Tuesday 3 p.m.

▼
Cover story

Instagram’s shift from a lifestyle hub to a political platform is profound. (‘From selfies to slogan’; April 5) However, balancing viral engagement with genuine democratic participation remains a critical challenge.
N.S. Reddy

▼
Attention spans today have reduced drastically. Be it long-form cricket or a full-length film, there are increasingly fewer takers for extended engagement. While social media platforms can easily enable the spread of hate, it remains to be seen whether Gen Z will also use them to strengthen participative democracy and promote constructive public participation.
A.R. Katamreddy

▼
It is very easy to shoot, upload and share fabricated or biased content on social media, but it is very difficult to handle the real on-ground situation. Let us make the wise use of this platform in the greater good of society.
Kirti Wadhawan

▼
Lasting impact
The work of Dalit writers whose oeuvres have touched a chord with readers and are turning into bestsellers indicates that while angst is ever-present, these public intellectuals are also tackling multifarious subjects that attract much interest. (‘Roots of resistance’; April 5) Their words are meticulously crafted and structured, the language is striking

and straightforward and the intention to create a lasting impression is evident.
C.V. Aravind

▼
Cultural ecosystem
It is amazing that Kochi-Muziris Biennale has demonstrated how art doesn’t merely inhabit spaces. (‘KMB needs a self-analysis’; April 5) One would hope that the guidelines Chopra lays out in his exit report would help the incoming team to ensure that KMB remains a living, breathing ecosystem in Kerala.
N. Rama Rao

▼
Raising awareness
We are living at a time when human-animal conflict is on the rise. (‘Krithi Karanth: rules of co-existence’; April 5) Social media has been instrumental in bringing attention to this issue, and it’s encouraging to now see growing awareness about human-animal interactions among the younger generation too.
Sajina Hameed

Correction

In the Magazine article ‘From selfies to slogan’ (April 5, 2026), the additional inputs were by M.P. Praveen. And in the article ‘Roots of resistance’, the name of the book suggested by scholar-activist Anand Teltumbde is *The Ambedkar Nietzsche Provocations*, and not as mentioned. The error is regretted.
— Editor



MORE ON THE WEB
www.thehindu.com/opinion/open-page

When debate becomes a spectacle

From its original concept of learning to understand, it has slowly transformed into a verbal bout
Mahima Roselin Varghese

An excess of photographs

The bid to save everything may have sullied the quiet art of remembering selectively
Raj Laxmi Verma

An egalitarian ‘sir’ culture

The word has become a profound embodiment of mutual dignity in Tamil Nadu
Bob Anand Rex

Quiet corners

They are psychological compromises, they reduce vulnerability while limiting participation
Akash S.

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